

Daily Content Intel

July 24, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, here's something I think about every single time I clear an athlete to go back after an ACL. We test strength, we test hop symmetry, we test change of direction, and when the numbers look good we send them back out. A study just came out on 822 patients after ACL reconstruction, and they checked three kinds of readiness at once: strength, performance, and psychological. All three of those lined up for less than a third of the athletes.

So most of the time the knee passes but the head does not, or the head is ready and the knee still lags behind. Think about what that means on the field. An

athlete who tests strong but is scared to plant and cut is going to move differently, and that hesitation is where a lot of second injuries come from.

So how do you close that gap? You measure the fear directly. There's a questionnaire called the ACL-RSI, and a score of 65 or higher is the marker that someone is psychologically ready. I want that number climbing right alongside the strength number before anybody plays a real game.

So if you or your kid is coming back from a knee, ask two questions. Is the leg strong and symmetrical, and do you actually trust it under pressure. Both have to be yes.

Does that make sense? Clear the whole athlete, not just the joint.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Your knee can be strong enough to play while your brain still is not, and that gap is where reinjuries happen.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, here's something I think about every single time I clear an athlete to go back after an ACL. We test strength, we test hop symmetry, we test change of direction, and when the numbers look good we send them back out. A study just came out on 822 patients after ACL reconstruction, and they checked three kinds of readiness at once: strength, performance, and psychological. All three of those lined up for less than a third of the athletes.

So most of the time the knee passes but the head does not, or the head is ready and the knee still lags behind. Think about what that means on the field. An athlete who tests strong but is scared to plant and cut is going to move differently, and that hesitation is where a lot of second injuries come from.

So how do you close that gap? You measure the fear directly. There's a questionnaire called the ACL-RSI, and a score of 65 or

higher is the marker that someone is psychologically ready. I want that number climbing right alongside the strength number before anybody plays a real game.

So if you or your kid is coming back from a knee, ask two questions. Is the leg strong and symmetrical, and do you actually trust it under pressure. Both have to be yes.

Does that make sense? Clear the whole athlete, not just the joint.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 The knee passed the test. Did the athlete?
- 0:12 822 patients. 3 kinds of readiness.
- 0:20 All 3 lined up for under 1/3 of them
- 0:34 Fear of cutting = where reinjuries live
- 0:48 ACL-RSI score of 65+ = psychologically ready
- 1:05 Clear the whole athlete, not just the joint

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Clearing an athlete after an ACL is one of the hardest calls I make.

We test strength, hop symmetry, and change of direction, and when the numbers look good we send them back. A new study on 822 patients found that strength readiness, performance readiness, and psychological readiness only lined up for less than a third of them.

So the knee can pass while the brain is still scared, and that hesitation to plant and cut is where a lot of second injuries live.

The ACL-RSI questionnaire puts a number on that fear. A score of 65 or higher is the marker of psychological readiness, and I want it climbing next to the strength numbers before anyone plays a real game.

Clear the whole athlete, not just the joint.

Ready to come back the right way? Start at threshold.clientsecure.me

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT

#ACLrecovery #returntosport #athletictrainer
#footballtraining #lacrosse #sportsPT

#physicaltherapy #ACLrehab #youthsports
#strengthandconditioning

Personalize this

- Name a specific football or lacrosse athlete you cleared back from an ACL where the strength numbers were there early but you held them because they did not trust the knee under a real cut. What did you have them do in that gap?
- Do you actually use the ACL-RSI (or a version of it) in your return-to-sport calls at Threshold, or do you read the fear a different way? Walk through how you score psychological readiness.
- How does this map to the CROSS framework and the way Threshold sequences return-to-sport, testing strength, symmetry, and readiness under fatigue rather than clearing on a calendar date?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/23259671261436441> |
"Psychological and Physical Readiness

Profiles for Return to Sport in Patients After Anterior Cruciate Ligament Reconstruction: An Analysis of 822 Patients"

- physiology | <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/23259671261436441> | "Psychological, strength-based, and performance-based physical readiness to RTS criteria align for less than one third of participants."
- actionable | <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/23259671261436441> | "The integration of both physical and psychological factors into a clinician's assessments of patient status allows for a holistic approach to care."

Sources:

- <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/23259671261436441>

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, hot take. Every August I watch high school teams run gassers and hit the track and call it speed work, and then everybody wonders why nobody actually got faster. Conditioning and speed are two different qualities. Conditioning gets you through the fourth quarter. Speed is its own thing, and you build it in the weight room.

There's a new network meta-analysis on football players that ranked every training method head to head. For the 30 meter sprint, strength training came out on top, with an 88.8 percent probability of being the best option. The barbell beat the running programs.

Same story for jumping. Strength training had a 94 percent probability of being the best method for vertical jump. If you want an explosive athlete, you

make them strong first, and the speed tends to follow.

So conditioning still has a job. It builds the engine so they hold up late in the game. If the goal is a faster, more explosive athlete though, the barbell comes first, and the running supports it.

Does that make sense? Stop trying to run kids into speed. Get them strong.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: You cannot run your way to speed, and the research is pretty blunt about it.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, hot take. Every August I watch high school teams run gassers and hit the track and call it speed work, and then everybody wonders why nobody actually got faster. Conditioning and speed are two different qualities. Conditioning gets you through the fourth quarter. Speed is its own thing, and you build it in the weight room.

There's a new network meta-analysis on football players that ranked every training method head to head. For the 30 meter sprint, strength training came out on top, with an 88.8 percent probability of being the best option. The barbell beat the running programs.

Same story for jumping. Strength training had a 94 percent probability of being the best method for vertical jump. If you want an explosive athlete, you make them strong first, and the speed tends to follow.

So conditioning still has a job. It builds the engine so they hold up late in the game. If the goal is a faster, more explosive athlete though, the barbell comes first, and the running supports it.

Does that make sense? Stop trying to run kids into speed. Get them strong.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 You cannot run your way to speed
- 0:10 Conditioning $\neq$ speed

- 0:22 30m sprint: strength training wins (88.8%)
- 0:34 Vertical jump: strength training wins (94%)
- 0:48 Strong first. Speed follows.
- 1:00 Get them strong.

Caption (copy-paste ready):

You cannot run your way to speed.

Every August I watch teams run gassers and call it speed work, then wonder why nobody got faster. Conditioning and speed are different qualities. Conditioning gets you through the fourth quarter. Speed gets built in the weight room.

A new network meta-analysis on football players ranked every training method head to head. For the 30 meter sprint, strength training came out on top with an 88.8 percent probability of being the best option. For vertical jump it was 94 percent.

Conditioning still has a job. It builds the engine so athletes hold up late in games. If the goal is a faster, more explosive athlete though, the barbell comes first and the

running supports it.

Want a program that actually builds speed?
threshold.clientsecure.me

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT

#speedtraining #footballtraining

#strengthandconditioning #lacrosse

#sportsperformance #athleticdevelopment

#youthathletes #getfaster #strengthcoach

#verticaljump

Personalize this

- What does your in-season vs offseason split actually look like for the HS football athletes you program? Where does true speed and strength work sit versus conditioning?
- Give a specific example of an athlete a coach was running into the ground who got faster once you shifted the emphasis to heavy, intentional strength work. What changed on the field?
- How do you talk a HS coach out of "more gassers = faster team" without losing them? What is the pitch you actually use for the barbell over the track?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1791257/full> | "The optimal dose of strength and conditioning training for enhancing physical performance in football players: a systematic review and network meta-analysis of randomized clinical trials"
- physiology | <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1791257/full> | "strength training exhibited the highest likelihood of being the most effective intervention for improving 30-meter sprint performance (SUCRA: 88.8%)"
- actionable | <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1791257/full> | "soccer players aiming to improve explosive power, linear sprint performance, and agility should prioritize targeted strength training"

Sources:

- <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/physiology/articles/10.3389/fphys.2026.1791257>

/full

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Soreness/DOMS is a poor indicator of training quality or muscle growth (reduced soreness usually reflects adaptation). Strong myth-bust, needs a fresh peer-reviewed primary rather than magazine coverage.
- Combined Nordic + reverse Nordic hamstring exercise improving fitness in youth soccer (Frontiers 2026) — hamstring durability angle, save for a return-to-sport week.
- Mode-of-injury effect on ACL psychological readiness (athletes injured in their primary sport show poorer emotional readiness) — pairs with today's Draft A for a follow-up.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest (2026-07-24, Mercola): 1 source, 0 educational links, pure promo (surplus sale, NAC/glutathione, pomegranate). Nothing clinically usable. Skipped.

- PubMed / Frontiers / journals — athlete-biased searches on: Nordic hamstring in youth football (heavily covered ground, passed), ACL reinjury + psychological readiness + return-to-sport criteria (HIT — fresh 822-patient study), adolescent protein/energy availability (recently cited 07-15, passed), static stretching myth (topic cited 07-15, avoided to prevent whiplash), conditioning vs speed for football (HIT — fresh 2026 network meta-analysis), DOMS/soreness myth (good but primary source thin, held as runner-up).
- Chose two fresh open-access primaries, both not in cited-sources.json.